



Unearthed Arcana

Combat Options

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The DUNGEONS & DRAGONS® game isn't any single play experience. Not only has the game been through several editions, but it also has appeared in the form of electronic games, choose-your-own-adventure books, board games, card games, dice games, and more. Add to that variety the version of the game played at each individual table, and you can begin to appreciate the rich array of possible play styles. We all create our own D&D® experiences through play.

This article offers new rules options to aid a variety of play styles. Options presented here run the gamut from classic concepts to elements from previous editions to wild ideas for fundamentally changing your game experience.

The purpose of these rules is to fire your imagination and show you different ways to play. It's your game. Play it in the way that's the most fun for you and your friends.

FUMBLES

Few die rolls are more frustrating than a 1 on a d20. An automatic miss means an opportunity lost, a resource spent, and an enemy alive. For some players, these results are bad enough. But others argue that a 1 ought to carry an additional result—especially since a natural 20 almost always means a critical hit.

Fumbles are to 1s as critical hits are to 20s. Just as each roll of a die gives you a chance to deliver a powerful hit, it also provides an equal chance that you'll

be in a bad position for responding to enemy attacks. The following rules options present different ways to handle natural 1s.

Characters relying on close and area attacks have more chances to roll 1s than do characters favoring single-target melee and ranged attacks. Although the wizard might have more chances to fumble, he or she also has more chances to score a critical hit.

Basic Fumble

Whenever you roll a natural 1 on an attack roll, after resolving all the other attack rolls for a close or area attack, your turn ends. You grant combat advantage until the start of your next turn.

Fumble Tokens

You can have fumbles change fate by using fumble tokens. Whenever a player rolls a natural 1 on an attack roll, the DM gains a fumble token. Whenever the DM rolls a natural 1 on an attack roll, the player group gains a fumble token.

When anyone scores a critical hit, the other side can spend a fumble token to treat the critical hit as a normal hit. In addition, anyone who rolls a natural 1 on an attack roll can spend a fumble token to reroll the attack roll after the other side gains a fumble token.

Random Fumble

The charm of a fumble is its unpredictability. Whenever you roll a natural 1 on an attack roll, after resolving all the other attack rolls for a close or area attack, make a saving throw and compare the result to the Random Fumbles table.

RANDOM FUMBLES

Roll	Result
1	You are stunned until the end of your next turn.
2	You are dazed until the end of your next turn.
3	You are weakened until the end of your next turn.
4	You are immobilized until the end of your next turn.
5	You provoke an opportunity attack from one enemy.
6	You fall prone.
7	Your turn ends, and you grant combat advantage until the start of your next turn.
8	You grant combat advantage until the start of your next turn.
9	You are slowed until the end of your next turn.
10+	No effect

INJURIES

Although the damage from a critical hit is impressive, it's just damage, and unless it's sufficient to drop or bloody the target, the critical hit has no other lasting consequences.

The injuries rules option boosts the effects of a critical hit by imposing a condition that hampers the foe's ability to fight and protect itself against further attacks. The following rules options supplement the normal rules for critical hits.

Just as fumbles are worse for creatures that can make multiple attack rolls each round, rules for injuries can benefit such creatures.

Basic Injury

Whenever you score a critical hit that bloodies the enemy, that target becomes injured (save ends). While injured, the target takes a -2 penalty to attack rolls and grants combat advantage.

Random Injury

For unpredictable results for injuries, whenever a critical hit bloodies a creature, the bloodied target must make a saving throw and compare the result to the Random Injuries table. The creature that scored the critical hit is the attacker.

RANDOM INJURIES

Roll	Result
1	Target is stunned until the end of the attacker's next turn.
2	Target is dazed until the end of the attacker's next turn.
3	Target is weakened until the end of the attacker's next turn.
4	Target falls prone.
5	Attacker pushes the target up to 1d4 squares.
6	Target grants combat advantage and takes a -2 penalty to attack rolls and to saving throws until the end of the attacker's next turn.
7	Target grants combat advantage and takes a -2 penalty to attack rolls (save ends).
8	Target grants combat advantage and takes a -2 penalty to attack rolls until the end of the attacker's next turn.
9	Target grants combat advantage until the end of the attacker's next turn.
10+	No effect

GROUP ACTION PHASE

After combat starts, it can be difficult to end without one side slaughtering the other. If you want to parlay, you risk doing nothing else during a round. If you want to flee, all it takes is one ally deciding to stay and fight to drag everyone back into the fray.

If one character wants to talk peacefully with the villain, all the other characters must cease hostilities, or the villain isn't liable to react well. Then, if the villain still fights, the characters have either wasted their turns or reset all their initiative counts into one big clump of readied actions.

If the players want to retreat, each character must leave on his or her initiative count. And unless everyone readies an action to flee when the last character's initiative count comes up, the initiative order could leave one character as the focus of all the enemies' attacks. If the group uses this tactic and someone is immobilized, slowed, or otherwise hung up, the whole party has wasted a round during a fight that probably wasn't going well in the first place.

Conscientious players can help avoid these troubles through good communication and a focus on fair play, but a DM might or might not take advantage of the players' plans. A good DM can sense when the story and excitement of play might be better served by letting the fight end, but that call can sometimes be hard to make.

Enter the group action phase! This rules option provides a phase at the end of each round wherein both sides decide if they fight, parlay, or flee. Using the group action phase is likely to result in more role-playing and more running away.

Parlay: If both sides want to parlay, the fight (but not the encounter) ends, and the interacting starts. If one side decides to parlay but the other chooses to fight, the fight continues as normal.

Flee: If one side decides to flee, and the other side allows it or also wishes to flee, the fight ends and the

interaction starts. Each side removes its incapacitated members from the scene if possible, and communication can occur in the meantime. Either side can later decide to pursue the other, resulting in a chase or tracking scenario (perhaps a skill challenge). The encounter ends only when both sides have separated.

If one side chooses to flee and the other side chooses to fight, then the fight continues as normal. The side that wishes to disengage then has to rely on the normal rules to do so.

Action Options

In the 3rd Edition of the game, some combat actions were options for any character. You can bring these options back to the table with the following material.

Overrun

Overrun lets you move through an enemy's space and keep moving without provoking opportunity attacks.

Overrun	Attack
<i>You power forward to break through the enemy ranks.</i>	
At-Will	
Standard Action	Personal
Effect: Move up to your speed. Each square you enter must be farther from where you started this movement. During this movement, you can use the following secondary power.	
Secondary Power	
Free Action	Melee 1
Trigger: You enter a square adjacent to an enemy, and you have enough speed remaining to move through the enemy's space without ending there.	
Target: The enemy you moved adjacent to	
Attack: Strength vs. Fortitude	
Hit: You can move through the target's space, but you can't end there. Your movement doesn't provoke opportunity attacks from the target until the end of your current turn.	
Miss: Your movement ends, and you provoke an opportunity attack from the target.	

Improved Overrun

You can knock foes out of your way as you move.

Prerequisite: Strength 13

Benefit: When using *overrun*, you gain a +4 feat bonus to the attack roll. If you miss with the attack made as part of your *overrun* attempt, you do not provoke an opportunity attack from your target.

Trampling Overrun

You run foes over as you move.

Prerequisite: Strength 13, Improved Overrun

Benefit: When you hit with the *overrun* attack, the target also falls prone. In addition, the secondary power of *overrun* requires no action (rather than a free action) for you, potentially allowing you to move through more than one creature's space.

Trip

Trip lets you knock an enemy prone.

Trip	Attack
<i>You knock your enemy from its feet.</i>	
At-Will	
Standard Action	Melee 1
Target: One creature	
Attack: Strength or Dexterity vs. Fortitude or Reflex (target's choice)	
Hit: The target falls prone.	
Miss: You provoke an opportunity attack from the target.	

Improved Trip

You know how to knock your foes down.

Prerequisite: Dexterity 13 or Strength 13

Benefit: When using *trip*, you gain a +4 feat bonus to the attack roll. If you miss with the attack made as part of your *trip* attempt, you do not provoke an opportunity attack from your target.

Knock Down

When you put an enemy down, you can make it want to stay down.

Prerequisite: Dexterity 13 or Strength 13

Benefit: When you make a melee attack against an enemy adjacent to you and score a critical hit, you can use *trip* as a free action. If an enemy adjacent to you uses the stand up action, you can make a melee basic attack against that enemy as an immediate reaction.

Disarm

This edition of the game lacks a disarm maneuver because of the problems it can cause and because it's a tactic that few have the skill to employ. But if you like the idea and are willing to adjudicate what happens when someone loses a weapon or item, consider adding the following disarm rules to your game.

Disarm	Attack
<i>You rip your enemy's weapon away.</i>	
At-Will	
Standard Action	Melee weapon
Target: One creature	
Attack: Strength or Dexterity vs. Fortitude or Reflex (target's choice)	
Hit: The target drops one item it is holding (your choice).	
Miss: You provoke an opportunity attack from the target.	

Improved Disarm

You've become an expert at disarming opponents.

Prerequisite: Dexterity 13 or Strength 13

Benefit: When using *disarm*, you gain a +4 feat bonus to the attack roll. If you have a hand free when you successfully disarm a target, you can take the item in your hand rather than causing the target to drop it. If you miss with the attack made as part of your *disarm* attempt, you do not provoke an opportunity attack from your target.

Sunder

A monster's equipment has little impact on its combat capabilities. Items are listed to help players visualize what the monster is doing. When you use *sunder*, however, you reduce the effectiveness of a foe's equipment instead of dealing damage.

Sunder

Attack

Rather than strike at your foe, you attack an object it carries.

At-Will ♦ Weapon

Standard Action **Melee weapon**

Target: One item that is not an artifact that a creature is holding or wearing

Attack: Strength vs. Reflex

Hit: Choose one of the following effects.

Weapon or Implement: A creature takes a cumulative -1 penalty to attack rolls using the weapon or implement until the end of the encounter. On a critical hit, the penalty equals 1d4 + 1. If the penalty equals -5 - the item's enhancement bonus, or worse, the item is destroyed.

Armor: A creature takes a cumulative -1 penalty to AC until the end of the encounter. On a critical hit, the penalty equals 1d4 + 1. If the penalty equals -5 - the item's enhancement bonus, or worse, the item is destroyed.

Other Items: The DM determines the effect. For instance, a potion bottle might shatter.

Miss: You provoke an opportunity attack from the creature holding the target.

Improved Sunder

You've become an expert at breaking items.

Prerequisite: Strength 13

Benefit: When using *sunder*, you gain a +4 feat bonus to the attack roll. If you miss with the attack made as part of your *sunder* attempt, you do not provoke an opportunity attack from the creature holding the target.

ACTION POINTS

Action points joined the D&D game in 3rd Edition's **EBERRON**® campaign setting. Their inclusion allowed players to nudge the game toward a more cinematic experience. Originally, you could spend an action point to add a variable number to any roll of a d20. *Unearthed Arcana*, from the same edition, offered additional options for players to boost feats and take special actions. All in all, action points proved an awesome resource for giving player characters an edge in combat.

Fourth Edition brought action points forward. Instead of adding to a die roll, action points now grant extra actions. Paragon paths grant extra benefits for spending action points, and feats and class features might modify action point effects even further.

The following rules options offer expanded effects for spending action points. Use as many of them as you find suitable for your game. If an option allows you to spend an action point to gain a benefit, you do not gain an extra action when you spend an action point in that way.

No Limits

During a combat encounter, a character can spend as many action points as he or she has.

The limits on action point expenditures help constrain their impact on combat encounters and ensure that play moves quickly, and they discourage hoarding for an important encounter.

If you choose to allow unlimited action point expenditures, paragon path and epic destiny features that allow characters to spend two or more action points per encounter should grant a character one extra healing surge instead.

Roll Bonus

When you make an attack roll, saving throw, ability check, or skill check, you can spend an action point to add 1d8 to the roll.

Damage Bonus

Whenever you roll damage, you can spend an action point to deal 1[W] extra damage if the attack was a weapon attack, or 1d8 extra damage if it wasn't. Only one target of the attack takes this extra damage.

Regain Encounter Power

When you miss with an encounter attack power, you can spend an action point to regain the use of that power. If you have the Psionic Augmentation class feature, you can spend an action point to regain the power points expended when you miss with an augmented at-will attack power.

Spend Healing Surge

You can spend an action point to spend a healing surge to regain hit points.

Cancel a Critical Hit

You can spend an action point when an enemy scores a critical hit against you. The enemy then treats the critical hit as a normal hit.

VARIABLE DEFENSES

Combat in the D&D game works with attack rolls made against static defenses. A creature's AC, Fortitude, Reflex, or Will gives a target number that the attack roll must meet or exceed. But what if you did it the other way around?

In concept, the switch is simple. Instead of having the attacker make an attack roll, assign all attacks a base value of 10 and apply the normal attack

modifiers. It's as if everyone rolls a 10 on the d20 when attacking.

Then apply the reverse logic to defenses. Instead of a defense of 10 plus modifiers, the defense is a d20 roll plus modifiers. A result that is equal to or lower than the attacker's static attack number is a hit. A roll of 1 on a defense roll makes the attack a critical hit. A roll of 20 makes the attack a miss, regardless of the attacker's attack number.

This change might not seem significant, but it can have interesting psychological effects upon how you view combat.

First of all, when your character makes an attack, you and the other players are watching the DM roll to defend. Likewise, when it's the DM's turn to make attacks, those targeted must actively roll to defend. Attention shifts from attacker to defender every turn. This play style can help everyone stay more engaged.

Secondly, you might start to see combat as less about how much you can bash down your foes and more about whether you can dodge and survive. This attitude shift can make some players more likely to avoid battle, even though the essential nature of combat remains unchanged. The net result of using variable defenses might be that combats in your campaign become less common and more interesting.

Rolling a 20 has been a cornerstone of the D&D game's culture for decades, but with the introduction of this mechanic, that result becomes less important. A critical hit actually happens when your enemy rolls a 1. Your roll of 20 just means that an attack misses you, and it probably wouldn't have hit if you had rolled a 15 or more.

This rules option essentially places the onus of the action on the defender. Instead of a critical hit representing an exceptionally well-delivered blow or powerful effect, it represents the target somehow fumbling its defense—ducking into the uppercut or dropping a shield just in time for the *fireball* spell's explosion.

The same attitude shift holds true for regular attacks as well. Because everyone uses a static attack value, every attack seems like the defender's opportunity to dodge rather than the attacker's opportunity to take control of the situation. The narrative focus shifts from what the attacker does to how the defender reacts. It's natural with variable defenses to describe how you duck out of the way rather than how you stab your enemy.

About the Authors

Robert J. Schwalb designs and develops roleplaying games and products, including stuff for D&D, *Warhammer Fantasy Roleplay*, *A Song of Ice and Fire*, and *Star Wars*. Rob's currently working on the next incarnation of the D&D game. For more information, check out his website at www.robertjschwalb.com or follow him on Twitter (@rjschwalb).

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